

Final Project Rubric

Final Project Grade Summary

The final project is worth 60% of the overall course grade, broken into the following deliverables:

Assignment	% of Overall Grade	Points
Abstract (Checkpoint 1)	5%	5 pts
Progress Summary (Checkpoint 2)	5%	5 pts
Final Paper	30%	30 pts
Final Presentation	20%	20 pts
Total	60%	60 pts

Checkpoint Deliverables

Checkpoint 1: Abstract

Due: March 10

Submit a concise one-paragraph summary (under 300 words) defining your topic, hypotheses, and planned methods. Include at least 10 references.

Checkpoint 2: Progress Summary

Due: April 7

Upload a 1-page summary of your project updates. Include problem statement, approach, dataset(s) or evidence gathered, and metrics or argument structure.

Checkpoint Rubric (applies to both submissions — 5 pts each)

Criterion	Pts	Excellent	Good	Developing	Inadequate
Required elements present	3	All required components addressed clearly and completely.	Most components present; one element thin or vague.	Several elements missing or underdeveloped.	Submission missing or does not address the prompt.
References / evidence	2	10+ relevant, peer-reviewed sources properly cited.	8–9 sources; mostly peer-reviewed.	Fewer than 8 or heavily non-scholarly sources.	No references or no scholarly sources.

Note: If your assignments received a COMPLETE grade on canvas, you already have 10 points in total for these assignments.

Final Paper: 30 Points (30% of Course Grade)

4–6 pages in length. Must use the provided LaTeX template (DS4024_final_project_template) under files on Canvas. Graded on quality of thinking and communication.

Criterion	Pts	Excellent	Good	Developing	Inadequate
Introduction & motivation	4	Context and research gap are precise. Explainability need clearly justified. Objectives are specific.	Context established and motivation reasonable. Minor gaps in justification.	Introduction present but vague. Motivation weakly connected to explainability.	Missing, off-topic, or no meaningful motivation provided.
Literature review	6	10+ scholarly sources synthesized critically. Identifies tensions, gaps, or debates. Clearly positions own work.	8+ sources. Some synthesis beyond summary. Adequate positioning.	5–7 sources. Mostly descriptive; connections between works are weak.	Fewer than 5 sources or no meaningful engagement with literature.
Methodology	6	Approach, data/evidence, and setup fully explained. Replicable. Tied to the research question.	Approach described with most details. Minor ambiguities in setup or data.	Methodology partially explained; gaps make it hard to evaluate.	Methodology absent or does not connect to research question.
Results & analysis	6	Findings presented clearly (with figures/tables if applicable). Interpreted with nuance. Connected to hypothesis or thesis.	Results presented adequately. Some interpretation offered.	Results present but surface-level. Little interpretation or connection to argument.	No results, or findings are unsupported by evidence.
Discussion & critical thinking	4	Limitations acknowledged. Complex points interrogated. Connects findings to broader XAI implications.	Limitations noted. Some interpretation of interesting findings.	Superficial discussion. Limitations absent or glossed over.	No meaningful discussion; restates results only.
Conclusion & future work	2	Contributions summarized clearly. Concrete, specific next steps proposed.	Adequate summary and reasonable future directions.	Conclusion present but vague or simply repeats the abstract.	Missing or does not address contributions.
Writing quality & format	2	Logical flow. Proper APA citations. Provided LaTeX template used correctly. Minimal errors.	Clear with minor issues. Template used; citations mostly correct.	Unclear in places. Poor organization or inconsistent citations.	Poorly written. Template not used. Citations missing.

A2: Final Presentation: 20 Points (20% of Course Grade)

Under 8 minutes, including questions.

Part I: Group Content — 10 Points (Shared Score)

All group members receive the same score for Part I.

Criterion	Pts	Excellent	Good	Developing	Inadequate
Content & argument	4	Key findings highlighted with depth. Argument flows logically. Frameworks applied meaningfully. Time well managed.	Reasonable structure. Most findings covered. Mostly on time.	Disorganized or missing major elements. Timing issues.	No coherent structure. Core content missing.
Explainability framing	4	Clearly explains the 'why' of the explainability approach. Connects accurately to course concepts (SHAP, LIME, Grad-CAM, etc.).	Explainability addressed but connection to course concepts could be stronger.	Cursory mention of explainability. Frameworks misapplied or unexplained.	Explainability framing absent or fundamentally incorrect.
Recommendations & engagement	2	Specific, actionable takeaways. Audience invited to engage (Q&A, poll, discussion prompt, etc.).	Reasonable recommendations. Some audience engagement attempted.	Vague or generic recommendations. Minimal engagement.	No recommendations or audience engagement.

Part II: Individual Delivery — 10 Points (Per Student)

Assessed individually using a separate scoring sheet during the presentation.

Criterion	Pts	Excellent	Good	Developing	Inadequate
Verbal clarity	2	Speaks naturally at an appropriate pace. Explains technical concepts accessibly.	Clear overall with minor hesitations or pacing issues.	Reads slides frequently. Uneven or rushed pacing.	Reads verbatim. Difficult to follow. Appears unprepared.
Command of content	3	Explains the WHY, not just the WHAT. Connects findings to course frameworks without prompting.	Understands material. Answers basic follow-up questions adequately.	Surface-level understanding. Confused when probed on own section.	Cannot explain own section. Defers all questions to teammates.
Audience awareness	2	Consistent eye contact. Reads the room. Confident, inclusive presence throughout.	Mostly engaged. Occasional lapses in eye contact or confidence.	Minimal eye contact. Speaks to slides rather than the audience.	No discernible audience engagement.

Criterion	Pts	Excellent	Good	Developing	Inadequate
Q&A performance	2	Responds thoughtfully. Connects answers to course concepts. Honest about uncertainty.	Adequate responses. Some connection to course ideas.	Vague or deflecting answers. Does not connect to course material.	Cannot address questions. No substantive answers given.
Transitions & teamwork	1	Smooth handoffs to teammates. Connects own section to prior/next. Attentive while others present.	Adequate transitions. Generally attentive to teammates.	Abrupt transitions. Partially disengaged when not speaking.	No transitions. Checked out during teammates' sections.

General Notes

1. Grades are based on quality of critical thinking and communication, regardless of whether your team has a technical experimental project or a paper position/ethical project.
2. AI tool use is permitted per SDS guidelines. All AI-assisted content must be properly cited. Students are responsible for the accuracy and integrity of submitted work.
3. If pursuing a more novel experiment with publication potential, contact ejh2wy@virginia.edu for additional support.

All work must be completed **by April 28, 2026**.